

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

TUESDAY 15 SEPTEMBER 2026



NOW BOTH DOORS ARE SHUT — A DRONE CLOSES SAUDI ARABIA'S PIPELINE AS THE HOUTHIS FINISH THE SECOND STRAIT, AND A FED THAT MEETS TOMORROW IS EXPECTED TO RAISE RATES INTO THE SHOCK

THE WORLD

Both of the peninsula's oil exits are blocked at once, the Oman talks collapse, and Brent tops a hundred and eight dollars

THE RABBIT HOLE

Modern board games, all the way down: the meeple, the deluxe box, the pile of shame, and the fifteen-billion-dollar hobby

THE ATELIER

Work boots, from the welt up — the leather and the stitch that decide everything, and where the price turns to theatre

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FROM THE DESK

"The four most dangerous words in investing are: 'this time it's different.'"

Sir John Templeton (attributed)

Templeton's warning cuts two ways this week. A Fed that raises rates *into* an oil shock rather than easing away from one is a genuine break with the last cycle's playbook — different, and the ten-year through five per cent says the market believes it. But the oil bulls calling for a hundred and forty dollars are making the other bet, that a war which has spilled no barrels yet somehow will. One of these is this-time-is-different; the desk's job on p14 is to say which.

THE STRIP • NEAR MONDAY'S CLOSE

Brent crude	\$108	▲ 4-mo high
Gold (spot /oz)	\$4,285	▼ -1.5%
Bitcoin	\$77,000	▼ risk-off
VWRA (All-World)	\$193.66	▲ near high
US 10-year	4.96%	▲ touched 5%
DXV (dollar)	99.4	▲ bid
USD/JPY	~154	▲ weak yen
STI	~5,800	▲ record

Levels near the 14 Sep close; USD/SGD ~1.268. The Fed decides Wednesday. Not advice — see p14.

THE WEEKDAY BOOK • HOW TO READ NO. 103

A straight news book this Tuesday: the wire leads, and the desks stay tight. Two hard stories set the weather — a Gulf oil war that has now closed both of the Arabian Peninsula's export routes at once, and a Federal Reserve that meets on Wednesday and is expected to raise rates straight into the price shock the war has caused. Everything downstream reads off

those two: the ten-year near five per cent, gold falling even as the shooting spreads, and a Singapore export print due the same day. The lighter desks earn their place without a forced theme — boots built to be resoled for decades, a watch that never needs a battery, a hobby measured by one obsessive database.

SOURCES Market levels: CNBC, TradingEconomics, Investing.com, Yahoo Finance near the 14 Sep close; USD/SGD via Wise. "From the Desk": quotation widely attributed to Sir John Templeton. Issue contents as laid out in this edition.

IRAN & THE GULF • THE SECOND DOOR SLAMS

A drone shuts Saudi Arabia's bypass, and now both of the peninsula's oil exits are blocked at once

The strike that closed the East-West pipeline — the one route built to skip Hormuz — dragged Riyadh into the war directly, collapsed the Oman talks the same day, and pushed Brent to a four-month high above a hundred and eight dollars.

For a fortnight the crisis was a standoff at one strait. Over the weekend it became a war for the whole peninsula. Drones — launched, Saudi officials say, from Iraqi soil — struck the East-West Crude Oil Pipeline, the five-million-barrel-a-day artery Saudi Aramco built precisely so its oil could reach the Red Sea without passing through Hormuz. Riyadh shut the line.¹ With that, the kingdom lost the one card it held against a blockade, and the last bypass around the contested strait went dark.¹

The diplomacy did not survive the news. The meeting that Gulf ministers and Iran were to hold in Oman on Monday — the first concrete step toward a shared Hormuz transit — was postponed within hours, with no new date; Oman's foreign minister, Sayyid Badr Albusaidi, cited "the interests of consensus," and Tehran said the delay came at Riyadh's request.² Iran kept the strait as leverage: its Supreme National Security Council repeated that Hormuz "will not open until the United States corrects its behaviour."²

The second gate is already gone. Houthi forces completed their seizure of Yemen's Red Sea coast over the weekend, taking the port of Mocha and, with Mayyun island, the Yemeni bank of Bab el-Mandeb.³ The two chokepoints together carry about a fifth of the world's seaborne oil; Hormuz traffic has thinned to a handful of tankers a day from more than a hundred, and Brent settled Monday near a hundred and eight dollars, a four-month high.³

~5m b/d

THE CAPACITY OF THE SAUDI EAST-WEST PIPELINE NOW SHUT — THE ONE ROUTE BUILT TO BYPASS HORMUZ, GONE THE SAME WEEK THE STRAIT'S OWN TRAFFIC COLLAPSED

TEHRAN

SNSC, VIA AL JAZEERA

Leverage, not a blockade. Hormuz stays shut "until the United States corrects its behaviour," but Tehran says it still grants commercial passage to China, India and Russia — a punitive tool aimed at Washington and its allies, framed as regional security that "belongs to the countries of the region."

DHAHRAN

SAUDI ARAMCO / AMIN NASSER

The chief executive argued the East-West line had done "more to stabilise oil markets than the massive US strategic-reserve release" — a pointed reminder that, with the pipeline now shut, the market's main shock-absorber has been removed just as it is most needed.

LONDON

IEA / REUTERS, AS ANALYSED

A pure supply shock, not a diplomatic story. The International Energy Agency calls the widening conflict the "largest supply disruption in the history of the global oil market"; the Western read is inflation and freight, and a premium that will not unwind until a barrel actually moves again.

THE CHATTER

Energy desks read Monday's tape as pricing the pipeline, not the water: the live premium is the vanished Saudi bypass on top of a near-halted Hormuz, and the moment it unwinds is the moment one route genuinely reopens. The collapsed Oman meeting keeps it in place.²

CNBC; Fortune; trade-flow data (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

The forecasters still fade the fear: zero barrels have actually been disrupted — the shut routes have re-routed oil, not destroyed it — and Brent "screens rich." Goldman Sachs' base case has crude falling back toward eighty-five dollars; the bet against oil is a bet that one gate reopens before the barrels run short.⁴

SOURCES 1 — CNBC, Bloomberg (11–13 Sep 2026): drone strikes (attributed to launches from Iraq) hit Saudi Aramco's East-West Crude Oil Pipeline (~5m b/d, the Hormuz-bypass route); Riyadh shuts the line. 2 — CNN, NPR, Al Jazeera (14 Sep): GCC-Iran Hormuz meeting (Oman) postponed, no new date (FM Badr Albusaidi, "interests of consensus"); Iran's SNSC — Hormuz shut "until the US corrects its behaviour," passage still granted to China/India/Russia. 3 — Times of Israel, Al Jazeera, NPR (11–13 Sep): Houthis take Mocha and Mayyun/Perim, completing the Yemeni Bab el-Mandeb bank (~12 mi from the African shore); ~20% of seaborne oil across the two straits; Hormuz transits down ~95%; Brent ~\$108, four-month high. 4 — Discovery Alert, FXStreet (14 Sep): analysts note "zero barrels disrupted," Brent screens rich; Goldman Sachs base case ~\$85 (vs Rystad ~\$140 bull). Forecasts flagged as forecasts; wording to confirm against live articles.

UKRAINE · THE WAR BRUSHES THE BORDER

A Russian drone lands two kilometres from NATO soil, and Washington asks Kyiv to stop hitting the refineries

The war reached the edge of the alliance on Sunday. Russian strike drones hit a filling station and a train within about two kilometres of the Polish border, close enough that Warsaw put its air defences on alert and Prime Minister Donald Tusk warned Moscow would “intensify” strikes along Ukraine’s frontier with the European Union.¹ Poland’s deputy defence minister, Cezary Tomczyk, called it “a serious escalation”; NATO’s secretary-general, Mark Rutte, promised more support for Kyiv. A drone two kilometres from Article 5 is a different order of risk than one over Kharkiv.¹

The other move this week runs straight into the oil story on the facing page. President Trump has pressed Ukraine to stop striking Russia’s oil refineries, citing the rising price of diesel worldwide — an unusually direct link between the eastern war and the pump, and a reminder that with the Gulf shut, no one wants a second front raising fuel costs.² Kyiv has made the refineries a signature of its deep-strike campaign; being asked to holster them, for the sake of Western fuel prices, is its own kind of pressure.

THE CHATTER

Analysts read the border strike two ways: a deliberate message to Europe, or the loosening discipline of a campaign firing more drones at longer range with less precision. Either way the risk is the same — the closer the war creeps to Polish soil, the smaller the margin for the accident that pulls NATO in. Treat “two kilometres” as the number that matters this week.¹

RFE/RL; Associated Press (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC · ON OUR OWN READ

We have flagged an eventual negotiated pause more than once; it has not come. The honest correction is that every framework this year has died on the same rock — the Donbas — and there is no sourced sign that rock has moved. A border incident raises the temperature; it does not, on its own, start or stop a war. Assume the tempo holds until a sourced delta says otherwise.

IN BRIEF · THE WIDER DESK

The diesel connection. Washington’s ask of Kyiv — ease off Russia’s refineries — and the shut Saudi pipeline are the same problem wearing two coats: a world short of refined fuel, worried a second front will make it shorter. The price of a barrel is now a diplomatic instrument on two continents at once.²

The dollar’s firmness. The oil shock has kept the dollar bid and the yen soft — the read-through the Macro Desk carries in full (p14): a ten-year that touched five per cent, a yen near a hundred and fifty-four, and a gold price that fell as the war widened, for reasons the desk explains.

A ferry down in the Java Sea. Indonesian rescuers searched for survivors after a passenger ferry capsized in bad weather off Java — the toll still firming as this issue went to press, a reminder that the region’s deadliest transport risk remains the everyday crossing, not the headline war.³

~2 km

THE DISTANCE FROM THE POLISH BORDER AT WHICH A RUSSIAN STRIKE DRONE HIT ON SUNDAY — THE CLOSEST THE WAR HAS COME TO NATO TERRITORY

A drone two kilometres from Article 5 is a different order of risk than one over Kharkiv.

Beijing’s quiet hedge. The country with the most to lose from a closed Hormuz is the one saying least: China takes roughly half its crude through the strait, and its move is not diplomacy but diversion — more Russian and Central Asian barrels, more overland pipe, less exposure to a sea lane it has no intention of policing.⁴

The chokepoint share. Between Hormuz and Bab el-Mandeb, roughly a fifth of seaborne oil now moves under threat — the number that has kept a war premium in crude since the spring, and the one the collapsed Oman talks will be judged against when, or if, they finally sit.⁴

The premium’s half-life. Every week the gates stay contested is a week the war premium compounds into fuel, freight and food; every credible off-ramp — a seated meeting, a reopened lane — is a week it unwinds. The crude price has become a barometer of diplomacy, read in dollars a barrel.

SOURCES 1 — RFE/RL, Associated Press (13–14 Sep 2026): Russian drones strike ~2 km from the Polish border (filling station, train); Poland on alert; PM Tusk warns of intensified border strikes; Dep. Def. Min. Tomczyk “a serious escalation”; NATO SG Rutte pledges support. 2 — Just Security, WORLD (14 Sep): Trump presses Ukraine to halt strikes on Russian oil refineries, citing global diesel prices. 3 — Anadolu, Just Security (14 Sep): passenger ferry capsizes in the Java Sea, Indonesia; search under way, toll not yet firm. 4 — Nikkei Asia, CSIS (analysis): China takes ~half its crude via Hormuz and is diversifying to Russian/Central Asian barrels; ~20% of seaborne oil under threat across the two straits. Wording to confirm against live articles.

THE HAZE TIPS OVER · A LAW THAT HAS NEVER BITTEN

The dry spell delivers: the air crosses into “unhealthy,” the cooling rooms open, and the one instrument that sounds like a remedy has still never worked

The twenty-four-hour index touched a hundred and forty-five by Tuesday’s small hours; a twenty-eight-agency task force has stood up its response plans and opened air-conditioned respite spaces; and the Transboundary Haze Pollution Act, invoked whenever the skies brown, has produced no successful prosecution in twelve years.

The warning in last week’s dry-spell forecast arrived on schedule. As recently as Saturday the air sat in the good-to-moderate band; by Monday afternoon the central region’s twenty-four-hour PSI had climbed from a hundred and two to a hundred and eight, and by the early hours of Tuesday the peak touched a hundred and forty-five — the middle of the “unhealthy” band.¹ The smoke drifts from fires in southern Sumatra and Kalimantan, dragged over the island by a shift to south-easterly winds, and the National Environment Agency expects it to persist while the dry conditions hold.¹

The government has moved from watching to acting. The Minister for Sustainability and the Environment, Grace Fu, told Parliament the twenty-eight-agency Haze Task Force had activated its response plans for schools, workplaces and community centres, that “selected air-conditioned community spaces may be used by those who need respite,” and that the haze “could be with us for a while.”¹ The household play is unglamorous: check myENV before the outdoor block, keep an N95 to hand. For a family the calculation is the child’s exertion — a reason to move sport indoors, not to cancel the day.

The week’s other argument closed without a vote. The salary statement reset the prime-ministerial benchmark from \$2.2m to \$3.6m and the entry-minister grade from \$1.1m to \$1.8m — a benchmark update on a one-off rise of up to nine per cent, effective 15 October.² The Workers’ Party’s Pritam Singh backed the one-off but rejected the top-earners formula and pressed again for full disclosure of total remuneration.²

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THE PEAK 24-HOUR PSI IN THE EARLY HOURS OF TUESDAY — THE ISLAND’S FIRST PUSH INTO THE MIDDLE OF THE “UNHEALTHY” BAND THIS EPISODE

THE CHATTER

Heartland sentiment runs to the practical and the resigned: air-purifier and N95 restocking, calls to work from home, and worry over the outdoor watch-parties for next month’s Grand Prix. The perennial “why can’t it be stopped at source” returns each time the index climbs.

Local forums (as reported; sentiment, not survey)

THE SCEPTIC

The instrument that sounds like a remedy is not one. The Transboundary Haze Pollution Act of 2014 lets Singapore pursue firms whose fires foul its air — and in twelve years it has produced no successful prosecution, because extraterritorial liability is worth little without Indonesian cooperation, which has not come. The haze is largely beyond the island’s hand; the cooling rooms, advisories and N95s are the real tools, not the law.¹

STILL ON THE SHELF

The export print to watch. August non-oil domestic exports land Wednesday from Enterprise Singapore; July ran twenty-four per cent higher year on year on an electronics surge, and RHB has lifted its full-year forecast to about fifteen and a half per cent.³

New bottoms for the uniform. From this term, MOE’s standardised secondary-school “bottoms” — skorts, smart shorts and joggers — become mandatory, a small back-to-school change for a Secondary One family (p12).³

Exam season. PSLE written papers run 24–30 September, with results tentatively late November — the backdrop to this fortnight’s Family Desk (p12).

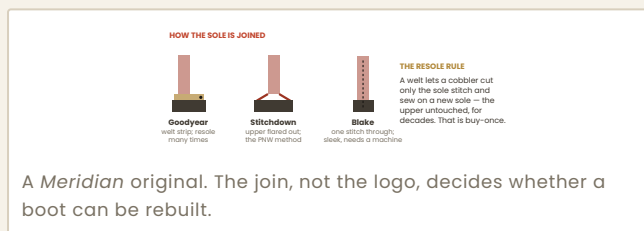
SOURCES 1 — NEA advisories (13–14 Sep 2026); Mothership, Xinhua, Tempo, Malay Mail: 24-hr PSI 145 (peak, early 15 Sep); central region 102–108 on 14 Sep, other regions 83–96; Sumatra/Kalimantan fires, SE–ESE winds; MSE Minister Grace Fu — 28-agency Haze Task Force response plans activated, air-conditioned respite spaces, “could be with us for a while”; Transboundary Haze Pollution Act (2014) — no successful prosecution. 2 — PMO newsroom, AsiaOne, The Star (8–10 Sep): PM benchmark \$2.2m–\$3.6m, entry grade \$1.1m–\$1.8m, one-off up to 9% effective 15 Oct; Pritam Singh backs the one-off, rejects the benchmark formula, MP allowance \$13,750–\$18,500, presses for disclosure. 3 — Enterprise Singapore/RHB (Aug NODX due 17 Sep; Jul +24.2%; FY forecast lifted to ~15.5%); MOE (standardised secondary bottoms mandatory 2026); SEAB (PSLE 24–30 Sep). Wording to confirm against live articles.

BUY IT ONCE • THE BOOT, FROM THE WELT UP

A boot is a leather upper joined to a sole — and how they are joined decides how many decades it lives

Learn two things — the hide and the stitch — and you can judge any boot on any shelf, cold, and see where the price stops buying wear and starts buying beauty.

Start with the leather, the single biggest cost and the biggest tell. **Full-grain** keeps the outermost, tightest, most water-resistant layer of the hide and ages into patina; **corrected-grain** is sanded smooth and sprayed to hide flaws, looks slightly plasticky, and cracks rather than mellows.¹ The default premium is Horween of Chicago — its Chromexcel, an oily “pull-up” leather whose scratches rub out under a warm thumb — while shell cordovan, the horse-hide grail, rolls rather than creasing and drives a boot past two thousand dollars.¹



Now the construction, because it decides whether the boot can be rebuilt. A **Goodyear welt** lets a cobbler cut only the sole stitch and sew on a new bottom, the upper untouched, many times over decades — the rational buy-once join, a resole fifty to a hundred dollars.² **Stitchdown**, the Pacific-Northwest work-boot method (White’s, Nicks, Viberg), is tank-tough but stiffer and usually resoled by the maker; **Blake** is sleek but wicks water. The sole finishes it — a wedge for all-day comfort, a Vibram lug for grip, leather for dress.²

The makers, by tier. The entry of quality is real full-grain leather on a resoleable welt, built offshore: Thursday’s Captain runs about two hundred dollars in Chromexcel, Grant Stone three to four hundred, Meermin around two.³ The rational buy-once band is American Goodyear-welt at scale — Red Wing’s Iron Ranger at \$349.99, its Classic Moc at \$359.99, Thorogood near \$275, the Alden Indy around \$730.³

Above it is small-shop craft: White’s MP-Sherman at \$749.95, Nicks’ Americana at \$674, Viberg’s service boot at \$1,300 — hand labour and the finishing you pay to admire.³

THE CHATTER • THE WHITE-LABEL TRUTH

The forums trade the same open secrets: Thursday sells an American-heritage look but builds in León, Mexico; Grant Stone is proudly made in Xiamen; Meermin builds in Shanghai and finishes in Spain. Alden is one of the few “heritage” claims that fully checks out. Buy the construction, not the surname.⁴

r/goodyearwelt; Stitchdown (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

Where the price turns to theatre: the jump from a \$350 Iron Ranger to a \$1,300 Viberg does not buy nearly four times the life — both resole indefinitely — and even the fans ask it, Stridewise heading its own review “Is it seriously worth thirteen hundred dollars?” The rational buy-once ceiling is the \$350–500 American-welt band; above it you pay for exotic leather and identity, not more wear.⁵

The Singapore reality: the tropics change the answer. A leather-lined, double-midsole PNW boot built for cold Cascade mud is heavier, hotter and more mould-prone than a Singapore desk-worker needs; a lighter unlined Goodyear-welt or a chukka is the smarter buy-once here. Red Wing has local retail, most US/Canadian makers ship direct, and Rugged Gentlemen Shoppe resoles through Dr. Sole.⁵

NEXT ON THE BENCH • YOU PICK THE CATEGORY

Glassware & stemware — mouth-blown vs machine-pulled, and why one universal glass beats a varietal set.

Coffee grinders — grind is the whole game: burr geometry, retention, and where the money goes.

Wooden cutting boards — end-grain vs edge-grain, and the heirloom that survives a humid kitchen.

SOURCES 1 — Stitchdown, Stock & Boer, Methuselah Leather: full-grain vs corrected-grain; Horween Chromexcel (combination-tanned pull-up) vs Dublin (veg-tanned) vs shell cordovan; combination tanning the boot default. 2 — BootSpy, Milwaukee Boot Co., Carmina, Stridewise: Goodyear welt vs stitchdown (the PNW method) vs Blake; resole —US\$50–100; sole types (wedge, Vibram lug, leather). 3 — maker pricing (~Sep 2026): Thursday Captain ~\$199, Grant Stone ~\$300–400, Meermin ~\$200; Red Wing Iron Ranger \$349.99, Classic Moc \$359.99, Thorogood ~\$275, Alden Indy ~\$730; White’s MP-Sherman \$749.95, Nicks Americana \$674 (22–28 wk), Viberg Service Boot \$1,300 (shell ~\$2,240). 4 — AllAmerican.org, Grant Stone journal, Stitchdown (Meermin/Carmina/Albaladejo; Yanko), Alden: origin/OEM truths. 5 — Stridewise (Viberg “worth \$1,300?”, Iron Ranger break-in), Hunter SG, ShoeTree Project, Rugged Gentlemen Shoppe/Dr. Sole (SG resole, humidity care). Some single-reviewer prices; confirm live before buying.

THE MODEL WAR · THE NUMBERS, THEN THE RETREAT

DeepSeek publishes the benchmarks, announces the old model's retirement — and then quietly takes it back

V4.1 Flash cleared its scores and undercut the price by three-quarters; the plan to silently reroute the previous model's traffic to it met a user revolt, and the retirement was withdrawn within days.

DeepSeek shipped V4.1 Flash on the tenth and, for once, showed its working. The model is a five-hundred-and-fifty-billion-parameter mixture-of-experts, native image-and-text, a million tokens of context, MIT-licensed — and its published benchmarks are the story last week's held item was waiting on.¹ Terminal-Bench, the agentic-coding test, jumped to ninety-point-six from the prior Flash's eighty-two-point-seven; the software-engineering score climbed from fifty-four per cent to seventy-four; GPQA Diamond reached ninety-point-nine.¹

Then came the manoeuvre, and the retreat. DeepSeek announced that from four o'clock in the morning, Greenwich time, on the fourteenth, every call to the older "V4 Pro" would be silently served by the cheaper, better Flash — at input roughly seventy-seven per cent cheaper and output about seventy per cent cheaper.² Users objected: some had tuned pipelines to the older model's exact behaviour, and a silent swap is a silent regression. Within days DeepSeek reversed course, keeping V4 Pro in service "in response to user demand," billing unchanged — and no V4.1 Pro has shipped at all.²

The episode is the whole DeepSeek posture in miniature: move fast, price low, occasionally overreach the user base. Flash's off-peak pricing — about fifteen cents per million tokens in, sixty out — is a fraction of the Western frontier's, and the appeal, as one forum put it, is the scrappy outfit "that refuses to play by Silicon Valley's billion-dollar rules."²

THE JUMP, IN NUMBERS



A Meridian original; scores per Artificial Analysis / DeepSeek's published card.

THE CHATTER

On r/LocalLLaMA and the DeepSeek boards the mood is opportunistic: users report stockpiling API credits at the new low prices before any correction, and three separate Hacker News threads pick over the benchmarks. The consensus framing is affectionate — the underdog that ships cheap and fast — tempered by the reminder that a company willing to swap your model out from under you is one to pin your version numbers against.²

r/LocalLLaMA; Hacker News (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

The benchmarks are real and the caveats are too. On DeepSeek's own harder-to-contaminate internal test the model still trails Anthropic's Opus — the gap narrowed, not closed — and testers report the web version follows instructions less reliably than the score implies.³ And "open weights" is not "runs at home": the reference recipe wants roughly six hundred and fourteen gigabytes of memory, which is the Home Lab's problem on the facing page (p8).³

Also on the desk: Nvidia has agreed to buy Hugging Face — the repository where most of these open weights live — for about twelve-point-nine billion dollars, closing in the first half of 2027; Jensen Huang pledges the platform "remains open" and that "Nvidia compute will not be required." For a home lab whose whole download stack now sits under Nvidia, that pledge is the thing to watch.⁴

The other sovereignty move is Meta's: its in-house "Iris" training chip, designed with Broadcom and fabbed by TSMC, was reported entering production this month — though a fresh taping-out confirmation had not surfaced by press time, so treat the timing as reported, not banked.⁴ The through-line is the chip war's: everyone wants to own the layer beneath the model, and no one wants to be a tenant.

SOURCES 1 — Artificial Analysis, llm-stats, buildfastwithai (10–13 Sep 2026): DeepSeek V4.1 Flash — 552B MoE, ~8–16B active, native image+text, 1M context, MIT weights; Terminal-Bench 2.1 90.6 (prev 82.7), DeepSWE 74.2% (prev 54.4), GPQA Diamond 90.9, Codeforces 3471. 2 — Superpower Daily, DataStudios, eesel AI, shattered.io (12–14 Sep): planned 14 Sep 04:00 UTC reroute of V4 Pro to Flash (~77% cheaper input, ~70% cheaper output) then reversed "in response to user demand," no V4.1 Pro; Flash pricing ~\$0.15/\$0.60 off-peak. 3 — MindStudio, Kingy AI: Flash trails Anthropic Opus on DeepSeek's internal DS-Bench Hard; ~614GB VRAM reference recipe. 4 — CNBC, NVIDIA blog (2–3 Sep): Nvidia to buy Hugging Face ~US\$12.9B, close 1H2027; CNBC/DCD (Jul–Sep): Meta "Iris" MTIA into production (reported, taping-out not fresh-confirmed). Some single-origin items flagged; wording to confirm against live articles.

THE HOME LAB · A MODEL YOU CAN'T RUN, ON MEMORY YOU CAN'T AFFORD

The open weights you can read but not run — and the single-card pick quietly moves on

V4.1 Flash's reference recipe wants six hundred gigabytes of memory, so for a home rig it is a rental, not a download; the practical daily driver steps up a generation, and the RAM to feed it keeps climbing.

The temptation with an MIT-licensed frontier model is to think it is yours to run. V4.1 Flash is not — not at home. The weights are half a terabyte; community quantisations land near a hundred and fifty gigabytes at their most aggressive; and the maker's own serving recipe calls for roughly six hundred and fourteen gigabytes of video memory, which is an eight-card H200 tray, not a desktop.¹ For this reader the model is an application-programming-interface play at fifteen cents a million tokens, not a card he loads. Open, in 2026, has stopped meaning local.¹

So the honest home-lab news is a smaller, better fit. The single-card daily driver moves up a generation, from the Qwen3.6 family the desk carried last week to Qwen3.8-27B — a dense twenty-seven-billion-parameter model, Apache-licensed, with vision and a native context that stretches past a quarter of a million tokens.¹ At a four-bit quant it fits in about eighteen gigabytes, comfortable on a twenty-four-gigabyte card, and runs on the usual stack of Ollama, LM Studio or vLLM. That is the frontier that actually sits on a desk; the headline one you rent.¹

The number that should move a decision, though, is still on a memory kit. A thirty-two-gigabyte DDR5 pair that cost eighty to a hundred and twenty dollars a year ago now runs close to four hundred — roughly three hundred and ninety at the August mark — as AI demand reallocates wafer capacity toward high-bandwidth memory, with high-end HBM supply prices up about a fifth again.² Analysts see the crunch persisting into 2027. For once the buy-once instinct and the buy-now instinct point the same way: if a rig upgrade is coming, secure the RAM first.²

The genuinely new decision this month, then, is a hardware one, not a model one — whether to buy the memory now, before the next leg up, or bet on a relief the analysts do not expect until late next year.²

SOURCES 1 — Artificial Analysis, MindStudio, Yotta Labs, llm-stats (10–14 Sep 2026): V4.1 Flash 552B MoE, MIT weights ~510GB, community quants ~150GB, reference serving ~614GB VRAM; Qwen3.8-27B (dense 27B, Apache, vision, 262K native context, ~18GB at Q4_K_M on a 24GB card, Ollama/LM Studio/vLLM). 2 — Wccftech, tech-insider, TrendForce (2026): 32GB DDR5-6000 kit ~US\$392 by Aug (vs \$110–140 a year earlier); HBM3E supply prices +~20%; crunch expected into 2027. Consumer-price specifics lean single-source; flagged. Qwen3.8-27B exact release date varies mid-Aug-early-Sep across sources.

The single-card stack itself is settled: a Qwen3.8-class model at a four- or five-bit quant, a fast local embedder, and a draft-and-verify setup for speed.¹

Still on the shelf. Unified-memory desktops — the boxes that trade raw bandwidth for capacity — are the quiet winners of a world where the model no longer fits the card; the home lab's centre of gravity is shifting from the GPU to the memory bus.

~\$392

A 32GB DDR5-6000 KIT BY AUGUST — UP FROM \$110–140 A YEAR AGO, A STRUCTURAL REALLOCATION TO AI MEMORY, NOT A NORMAL PRICE CYCLE

THE CHATTER

The local-model boards are split between excitement at another open frontier model and a shrug that it fits nobody's desk: "great weights, wrong hardware" is the running line, and the six-hundred-gigabyte figure is the punchline. On memory the sentiment is unambiguous — the r/buildapc and homelab threads have turned into a "buy the RAM now" chorus, with screenshots of last year's prices held up as evidence.²

r/LocalLLaMA; r/buildapc (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

The benchmark cannot referee this. Vendors report on non-overlapping suites, so a launch score is marketing until a third party reconciles it — and on DeepSeek's own harder internal test the model still trails the Western frontier (p7). Judge a local model on what it does in your own workflow, on your own card — the only benchmark that pays your electricity bill. And on the RAM: the "buy now" chorus is real, but a panic-buy at four hundred dollars is still four hundred dollars; buy what a real upgrade needs, not the fear.²

STILL ON THE SHELF

The Hugging Face question. The repository these open weights live on is being bought by Nvidia (p7); nothing changes for a downloader today, but a home lab whose whole stack now sits under one vendor should keep a local mirror of the weights it depends on.

GEAR WE'RE WATCHING · THE WATCH YOU REPLACE EVERY YEAR

Apple's Ultra 4 adds a day of battery and a new sensor stack for the same eight hundred dollars — and the case for sitting the year out

The 49-millimetre titanium flagship gains the S11 chip, a longer battery and a redesigned health-sensing system, and a new black-titanium finish; blood-pressure sensing, a microLED screen and Touch ID all failed to make the cut.

The gear story of the week is the one the optimiser already half-owns. Apple unveiled the Watch Ultra 4 on the ninth, opened pre-orders, and set shipping for Friday the eighteenth — forty-nine millimetres of titanium, now in a natural and a new black finish, at seven hundred and ninety-nine dollars, unchanged from the Ultra 3.¹ The first hands-on impressions circulated across the weekend, and the shape of the upgrade is clear: a sensor-and-battery year, not a reinvention.¹

What is new is real but incremental. The S11 chip replaces the S10; battery life climbs to about fifty hours from forty-two, with a forty-five-hour Max Extended Workout mode for the ultra-endurance crowd; and a redesigned Health Sensing System brings larger ECG electrodes and a ring of photodiodes for steadier readings, alongside dual-frequency GPS.¹ Satellite messaging carries over. What did not arrive is the more telling list: the long-rumoured blood-pressure sensing, a microLED display and any return of Touch ID all missed the cut.²

Which is why the owner verdict is measured rather than breathless. On the MacRumors forums, Ultra 1 and 2 owners describe it as “not an obligatory upgrade” — one at ninety-three per cent battery health is staying put — and reviewers frame it as “a sensor-and-battery upgrade rather than a connectivity one,” because last year's Ultra 3 already brought satellite.² For someone timing a first Ultra, it is the obvious buy; for someone on a one- or two-year-old model, the reasons to move are narrow.²

\$799

THE ULTRA 4, UNCHANGED FROM THE ULTRA 3 — THE SAME PRICE, A DAY MORE BATTERY, A NEW SENSOR ARRAY, AND A YEAR'S DEPRECIATION ON THE ONE YOU OWN

THE CHATTER

The upgrade guides converge on the same advice: the fifty-hour battery and the new health array are the genuine gains, and everything else is polish. The endurance-sport threads are the exception — the Max Extended Workout mode is a real answer to a multi-day race — but the mainstream read is that an Ultra 2 owner loses nothing by waiting for the blood-pressure feature that keeps not shipping.²

MacRumors forums; the5krunner (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

For a buy-once-cry-once reader this is the opposite kind of object: an eight-hundred-dollar wrist computer that is, honestly, a consumable, refreshed on an annual clock and depreciating the day it ships. The health sensing is the only part that compounds — better data every year — and it is precisely the part Apple keeps holding back. The clean discipline is to buy an Ultra when you have none, then skip two generations. A gadget that improves five per cent a year does not earn a yearly upgrade.¹

STILL ON THE SHELF

The quieter buy-once pick. Noble Audio's Iris, a six-hundred-and-ninety-nine-dollar single-dynamic-driver in-ear with a Micarta shell and a swappable cable, is drawing its first reviews this month — a genuine entry point to top-tier listening that, unlike a smartwatch, will sound the same in a decade.³

Also watched. DJI's Osmo Action 6 adds a variable aperture — an action-cam first — on a larger sensor; no firm on-sale peg landed this week, so it stays a bench item, but it is the non-Apple secondary camera worth tracking.³

SOURCES 1 — Apple Newsroom, Smartwatch Insight (9 Sep 2026): Apple Watch Ultra 4, 49mm titanium (natural + black), US\$799, pre-orders open, ships Fri 18 Sep; S11 chip, battery ~50h (from 42) + 45h Max Extended Workout, new Health Sensing System (larger ECG electrodes, ring photodiodes), dual-frequency GPS, satellite carried over. 2 — MacRumors forums, the5krunner (12–14 Sep): no blood-pressure sensing, no microLED, no Touch ID; owner/reviewer read “not an obligatory upgrade,” “sensor-and-battery, not connectivity.” 3 — ecoustics, Tom's Guide (Noble Audio Iris US\$699, single DD, Micarta shell, first reviews Sept); actioncameraview (DJI Osmo Action 6, variable aperture, no confirmed peg). Pricing as announced; confirm at launch.

OBJECTS & ESCAPES · A BATTERY YOU NEVER CHANGE

Citizen reissues its 1973 “bullhead” for fifty years of light-powered movements — a solar chronograph with a mechanical trick

The Promaster Tsuno Chrono Racer marks half a century of Eco-Drive with a flyback chronograph that never needs a battery for the life of the watch — and asks you to pay for the design story, not the movement.

The object earns its interest at the geometry. Citizen’s new Promaster Tsuno Chrono Racer, reference AV0104-06W, reissues a 1973 “bullhead” — the crown moved to twelve o’clock, flanked by two oversized pushers that give the case its horns, *tsuno* in Japanese.¹ It is a forty-four-and-a-half-millimetre two-tone steel-and-gold case with a British-racing-green dial, sapphire crystal, two hundred metres of water resistance and a brown leather strap — one of two limited pieces released on the tenth to mark fifty years of Eco-Drive.¹

Inside is where the trick lives. The Tsuno runs the Caliber E210, a light-powered Eco-Drive quartz movement with a one-fifth-second flyback chronograph — the hands snap instantly back to zero, a behaviour usually reserved for mechanical chronographs — and, because it charges on light, it “never needs a battery for the life of the watch.”¹ It is limited to five thousand unnumbered pieces, ships in a custom tackle box, and lists at one thousand three hundred and fifty US dollars — about one thousand eight hundred and eighty-six Singapore dollars with tax — alongside a Skyhawk companion near a thousand.¹

50 yrs

OF ECO-DRIVE — THE LIGHT-POWERED MOVEMENT THAT MADE “NEVER CHANGE THE BATTERY” THE WHOLE PITCH, MARKED BY THIS REISSUE

The buy-once case is unusually literal. A mechanical watch wants a service every few years and a daily winding; a battery quartz wants a new cell and a case-back opened. Eco-Drive wants neither — light through the crystal keeps it running — so a collector frames it as the ultimate grab-and-go tool watch, and that permanence is the reason the quirky bullhead has a cult.²

You are buying a case shaped like 1973 and a battery you never change — not a movement that keeps closer time than the cheap one.

For the Singapore buyer the sums are simpler than a mechanical’s. It is widely listed through Citizen retail near one thousand nine hundred dollars, and the run of five thousand is generous enough that there is no scramble — a watch to try on, not to chase.¹

THE CHATTER

On WatchUSeek the Tsuno line runs as a cult favourite — the quirky twelve-o’clock-crown geometry is exactly what its fans love — and aBlogtoWatch has long praised the model’s value and wearability. The enthusiast framing of Eco-Drive is consistent: the grab-and-go watch you never have to think about, which is precisely the appeal and precisely the limit.²

WatchUSeek; aBlogtoWatch (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

Here the usual knock inverts. Quartz is already more accurate than any mechanical, so you are not paying for a worse movement — you are paying roughly nineteen hundred Singapore dollars for a solar-quartz calibre that costs a fraction of a Swiss mechanical, the premium going to 1973 nostalgia, a “fiftieth anniversary” sticker and a tackle box. The value case rests entirely on the design story — which is fine, so long as you know that is what you are buying.¹

The buy-once read: a light-powered movement removes the two recurring costs of watch ownership — the battery change and the service — and a sealed solar cell will typically outlast a decade of daily wear, which is the quiet, honest case for an Eco-Drive over both a battery quartz and an entry mechanical.²

SOURCES 1 — Citizen Watch (global press release, product page), Notebookcheck, Deployant, Sakura Watches (1–10 Sep 2026): Promaster Tsuno Chrono Racer AV0104-06W, 1973 bullhead reissue, 44.5mm two-tone steel/gold, British-racing-green dial, sapphire, 200m, Caliber E210 Eco-Drive with 1/5-sec flyback chronograph; limited 5,000 unnumbered, released 10 Sep, tackle-box packaging; US\$1,350 / ~\$1,885.70 incl. GST (one SG retailer); Skyhawk companion ~US\$1,000. 2 — WatchUSeek, aBlogtoWatch (Tsuno line as cult favourite; Eco-Drive framed as the grab-and-go buy-once tool watch). SGD figure from a single SG retailer; confirm before buying.

CULTURE DESK · THE STATUETTES, HANDED OUT OVERNIGHT

“The Pitt” takes Drama for a second straight season, while Apple’s freshman “Widow’s Bay” storms Comedy on a record haul

The seventy-eighth Emmys, handed out in Los Angeles on Monday night, set old-guard prestige against Apple’s deep-pocketed newcomers — and both won: a medical procedural repeated at the top, and a first-year comedy swept in on the studio’s biggest-ever nomination year.

Awards season opened where it left off. At the seventy-eighth Primetime Emmys, staged at the Peacock Theater in Los Angeles on Monday night and hosted by Mariska Hargitay, HBO Max’s “The Pitt” won Outstanding Drama Series — its second win in a row, for its first two seasons, a feat only a handful of dramas have managed.¹ The real-time emergency-room procedural, created by R. Scott Gemmill for John Wells Productions and led by Noah Wyle as Dr. Robby, had gone in the front-runner with a category-leading twenty-five nominations.¹

The comedy race told the other half of the year’s story. Apple’s first-season “Widow’s Bay” won Outstanding Comedy Series, having already swept the Creative Arts ceremony a week earlier with eight trophies, including a guest turn from Betty Gilpin — and having gone in with nineteen nominations against the twenty-four of “Hacks,” which bowed out with its fifth and final season empty-handed.¹ Apple posted a record eighty-nine nominations across 2026, its biggest haul ever; the limited-series night went to “DTF: St. Louis,” which took supporting honours for David Harbour and Linda Cardellini alongside its writing and directing.¹

Read together, the night was a contest between two kinds of television money — the sustained-craft incumbents rewarded for doing a hard thing twice, and a streamer with the deepest pockets in the business converting a record nomination year into hardware. That both walked away with a top prize is the state of the industry in one evening: prestige still wins the drama, and the biggest cheque wins the comedy.¹

THE CHATTER

“The Pitt” is the rare critics’ darling that also rates — an unpretentious procedural credited with restoring “competence porn” that audiences turned into a tentpole. Its repeat win read online as the Academy rewarding sustained craft; the counter-chatter was all about Apple’s spending, and whether a freshman comedy earns a sweep or buys one.¹

Variety, IndieWire (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

Two discounts on the night. A back-to-back drama win is as much a thin, transitional field as it is greatness — the 2026 slate leaned on returning franchises and unproven newcomers, giving an incumbent an easy lane. And a record eighty-nine nominations tracks marketing and campaign spend at least as closely as merit; a well-funded crafts sweep is a studio flexing, not proof of the year’s best comedy.¹

ALSO ON THE DESK

The “Hacks” send-off. Jean Smart’s comedy took its fifth and final bow with twenty-four nominations and no wins — the Emmys rewarding the newcomer’s momentum over the veteran’s farewell.¹

Still on the calendar. A24’s “Primetime,” the Pattinson predator-hunter drama the desk flagged from Venice, opens wide on the twenty-fifth — the box-office test of whether festival heat converts, still a held item this fortnight.²

89

APPLE’S EMMY NOMINATIONS ACROSS 2026 — ITS BIGGEST YEAR EVER, AND THE ENGINE BEHIND “WIDOW’S BAY’S” COMEDY SWEEP

Prestige still wins the drama; the platform with the biggest cheque wins the comedy.

SOURCES 1 — Television Academy (nominees & winners), GoldDerby, Variety, IndieWire (14 Sep 2026): 78th Primetime Emmys, Peacock Theater LA, host Mariska Hargitay; Outstanding Drama Series “The Pitt” (HBO Max, back-to-back, 25 noms; Noah Wyle/R. Scott Gemmill/John Wells); Outstanding Comedy Series “Widow’s Bay” (Apple TV, 19 noms, Creative Arts sweep incl. Betty Gilpin); “Hacks” 24 noms, final season, no wins; limited series “DTF: St. Louis” (David Harbour, Linda Cardellini); Apple record 89 noms. 2 — Deadline, La Biennale (Sep 2026): A24 “Primetime” (dir. Lance Oppenheim; Pattinson), US wide release 25 Sep. Wording to confirm against live listings.

RAISING THEM WELL • THE LOWEST IN THIRTY YEARS

Teen sleep hits a thirty-year low, right on the twelve-year-old band — and the reason is not, mostly, the phone

The largest look yet at how much American adolescents sleep finds every age group at a three-decade low, with the steepest deficit at twelve and thirteen — and the same decade of data quietly clears the smartphone of being the whole story.

The number lands squarely on a Secondary One family. A study published in *Pediatrics* this year, drawing on more than four hundred thousand American adolescents surveyed between 1991 and 2023, found that the years 2021 to 2023 recorded the lowest share getting at least seven hours of sleep at every single age — and the band that fares worst is the youngest measured. Only thirty-seven per cent of twelve- and thirteen-year-olds now clear seven hours, falling toward twenty-two per cent by eighteen and nineteen, each age at a thirty-year floor.¹ By a companion measure, fewer than a third of twelve- and thirteen-year-olds even *feel* they get enough.¹

Now the sentence that reframes it. The decline began in 1991 — well before the smartphone existed — and the researchers caution that screens “may not be primarily to blame.”¹ The wider evidence agrees: the Oxford psychologists Amy Orben and Andrew Przybylski have pegged digital technology to roughly four-tenths of one per cent of the variation in adolescent wellbeing — about, as they put it, as much as eating potatoes.³ A parent who trims the feed and calls it done has treated a symptom and missed the disease.³

The disease has a systemic lever, and it is the clock. A separate 2026 analysis found that later school-start times yield measurably more sleep and better academic performance in adolescents — the single largest intervention available, and one no individual family controls.² Singapore’s own numbers show why it matters here: schools are asked to start no earlier than half past seven, Duke-NUS research puts secondary students near six and a half hours a night against the eight to ten recommended, and a 2024 resilience study found about eighty-five per cent of them feel unrested. A Workers’ Party member

pressed the ministry on later start times in Parliament this year.²

37%

OF TWELVE- AND THIRTEEN-YEAR-OLDS NOW GET AT LEAST SEVEN HOURS’ SLEEP — THE LOWEST IN THE THIRTY YEARS THE SURVEY HAS RUN

What the study does not license is another confiscation. The honest takeaway for a twelve-year-old is structural, not punitive: protect the sleep window as a household rule rather than nag the child, treat the biggest single lever — a later school start — as a system problem and not a parenting failure, and aim for the eight-to-ten-hour band while treating chronic six-and-a-half-hour nights as a flag worth raising with the school or a doctor.¹ This is general guidance, not medical advice.¹

THE CHATTER

Parent sentiment locally runs to the resigned and the practical: co-curricular activities, tuition and the phone all compete for the same evening hours, and the “just take the phone away” advice collides with the class group chat where the homework actually lives. The study gives the tired parent a gift — permission to stop blaming a single device and start defending a single hour.¹

Parent forums (as reported; sentiment, not survey)

THE SCEPTIC • AGAINST THE PANIC

Two honest limits. The headline study is on American teens, is self-reported, and measures sleep, not any brain outcome — do not smuggle a cortex scare in through a sleep chart. And the “screens ruined sleep” story is exactly the one the thirty-year trend undercuts: the fall predates the phone, so the phone is at most an accelerant on a curve that was already bending. Watch the hours slept and how the child functions the next day — not the clock on the app.³

SOURCES 1 — Widome R et al, “Sleep Duration Among US Adolescents, 1991–2023,” *Pediatrics* (2026; DOI 10.1542/peds.2025-074933): n=401,160 (Monitoring the Future); 2021–23 lowest-ever share ≥7h at every age, 37.2% at 12–13 falling to 22.3% at 18–19; AAP News (only ~29% of 12–13s feel they get enough; decline predates smartphones, “screens may not be primarily to blame”). 2 — ScienceDaily (11 Mar 2026): later school-start times → more sleep and better performance; Duke-NUS/MOE (SG secondary ~6.5h vs 8–10; ~85% feel unrested; schools start ≥7:30am; WP MP Dennis Tan). 3 — Orben & Przybylski (digital tech ~0.4% of adolescent wellbeing variance); Psychology Today, NPR (2026). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE LEVER THAT ISN'T THE PHONE

If you change one thing this term, change bedtime — sleep is where the screen actually does its damage

If the facing page has one instruction, it is this: the most useful move a parent of a twelve-year-old can make this term is not a new app rule but an earlier lights-out. The thirty-year sleep decline (p12) is the disease; the phone in the bedroom is the accelerant, the mechanism that turns six and a half hours into six. Local data already has secondary-school students near that six-and-a-half-hour mark against the eight to ten recommended, so the deficit is not a future risk here — it is the current baseline.¹ Guard the sleep and much of the “screen harm” the headlines fear takes care of itself.¹

The framework already exists to lean on. “Grow Well SG” sets a floor most families can hold — under two hours of non-schoolwork screen time a day for the seven-to-twelves, and phones stored during lessons — and the transition into secondary school is the natural moment to renegotiate the household rules while the child still expects them to change.¹ The band matters: guidance written for a ten-year-old is not guidance for a twelve-year-old entering a world of group chats and homework that lives online.²

The secondary-school transition is where the rules quietly break, because the phone stops being a toy and becomes the class group chat, the homework portal and the way plans get made after three o'clock.² A blanket ban that made sense at ten collides with a twelve-year-old's real social and academic life; the workable version is narrower and firmer — the device out of the bedroom overnight, notifications off during homework and sleep, and a standing rule that meals and the last hour before bed are screen-free for the whole household, adults included.²

Model it, in other words, rather than merely mandate it. The research that holds up best is unglamorous and reciprocal: children whose parents guard their own sleep and put their own phones down keep the rules better than children handed a contract, because a twelve-year-old reads hypocrisy faster than any content filter.¹

THE TOOLKIT

bescreensmart.gov.sg collects the local screen-use guidance for this exact band, from time floors to family-

SOURCES 1 — Duke-NUS / MOE survey data (as reported): secondary students ~6.5h weeknight sleep vs 8–10 recommended; “Grow Well SG” guidance (<2h/day non-schoolwork, ages 7–12; phones stored in lessons). 2 — Al Jazeera, Knowable Magazine (Aug 2026): Australia's under-16 social-media ban (switched on 10 Dec 2025) — e-Safety Commissioner finds >80% of under-16s still using; ~4.7m suspected under-age accounts deactivated in month one; Singapore age-assurance law due early 2027. General guidance, not medical advice.

agreement templates — the state's own version of the boring advice, in one place.¹

The one dial to move. If a household changes a single setting this term, make it the overnight charge point: a phone that sleeps in the kitchen fixes the sleep, the doom-scroll and the 2am group chat in one rule, without a single argument about screen time.¹

THE CHATTER · THE LONGEVITY CROSSOVER

The optimiser parent will notice the overlap with the adult longevity discourse: protect sleep, protect daytime movement, and defend both from whatever erodes them. The Fitness Desk makes the mid-forties version of the same argument this fortnight (p18) — that the easy thing which quietly removes your movement is the thing to watch. The cheapest interventions in the house are boringly consistent across the ages.

Duke-NUS / MOE survey data (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC · THE BAN THAT DIDN'T

Watch what a hard law actually does. Nine months after Australia switched on its world-first under-sixteen social-media ban last December, its own e-Safety Commissioner found more than eight in ten under-sixteens still using the platforms, much as before — even after companies deactivated some four-point-seven million suspected under-age accounts in the first month.² Singapore's own age-assurance law arrives in early 2027; the Australian data is the caution to carry into it. A floor changes the default; it does not change the child.²

STILL ON THE SHELF

Exam-season sleep. With PSLE written papers running 24–30 September (p5), the sleep lever is doubly worth pulling this fortnight — for the younger siblings sitting them, and the Secondary One pupil watching how the house handles pressure.

New uniform, same routine. The standardised secondary “bottoms” are mandatory this term (p5) — a small back-to-school reset, and a natural moment to renegotiate the overnight-charging rule while the child still expects the rules to change.

Change bedtime, not the birthday on the account: sleep is where the screen actually bites.

THE BIG PICTURE · THE HIKE INTO THE SHOCK

An oil shock meets a Fed expected to raise into it — and gold falls as the war widens

Both peninsula oil routes are shut, the crude premium has become an inflation fear, and the fear has the market pricing a rate hike on Wednesday. The counter-intuitive tell is gold: it fell this week, which tells you what kind of regime this is.

Follow the chain, because this week it runs unusually straight. Both of the Arabian Peninsula's oil exits are now blocked — the Saudi bypass pipeline shut, Bab el-Mandeb seized (p3) — and Brent has settled near a hundred and eight dollars, a four-month high.¹ Dear oil is an inflation impulse, arriving just as a hot American consumer-price print landed on the eleventh; together they have the new chair Kevin Warsh's Federal Reserve positioned to raise rates at Wednesday's meeting, with futures putting the odds near eighty-five per cent — a hike into a supply shock, the opposite of the cuts the year began expecting.¹ The ten-year Treasury yield answered by touching five per cent for the first time since 2023.²

BRENT	US 10Y	GOLD /OZ	BITCOIN	VWRA	D
\$108	4.96%	\$4,285	\$77k	\$193.7	91

The tell is what gold did. In a clean geopolitical panic gold rises; this week, with a shooting war widening across two straits, it *fell* about a percent and a half, to around four thousand two hundred and eighty-five dollars.² The reason is the whole regime in one move: rising real yields and a firmer dollar — the dollar index bid near ninety-nine and a half — outweighed the haven demand. This is not stagflation fear bidding up safety; it is a higher-for-longer, dollar-bid, real-yields-up regime, in which the price of money rose faster than the price of fear.² Bitcoin told the same story, sliding toward seventy-seven thousand as a liquidity-sensitive risk asset, not a haven.²

5.00%

THE US 10-YEAR YIELD'S INTRADAY TOUCH ON MONDAY — THE FIRST TIME IT HAS REACHED FIVE PER CENT SINCE 2023

~85%

FUTURES-IMPLIED ODDS OF A FED HIKE ON WEDNESDAY — A RAISE INTO AN OIL SHOCK, THE DEFINING ANOMALY OF THE REGIME

SOURCES 1 — CNBC, TradingEconomics, CME FedWatch, Fortune (11–14 Sep 2026): Brent ~\$108 (4-mo high); hot US CPI 11 Sep; FOMC 15–16 Sep (decision 16th), CME ~85% hike odds (prediction markets ~48–49%), Chair Kevin Warsh, Fed blackout. 2 — TradingEconomics, Investing.com, Yahoo Finance (12–14 Sep): US 10Y ~4.96% (touched 5.00% Mon, first since 2023); DXY ~99.4; gold ~\$4,285 (–1.5% d); BTC ~\$77k (–5–6% wk); VWRA ~\$193.66; STI ~5,802; USD/JPY ~154; USD/SGD ~1.268. 3 — Discovery Alert/FXStreet (Goldman base case ~\$85, “zero barrels disrupted”); Meridian analysis. A global-aggregate bond level could not be verified this build and is held. Some spot levels single-sourced. Market explanation, not investment advice.

WHAT IT MEANS · VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

Read through the four instruments. Global equities (VWRA) sit resilient near a record, but face a rate-and-oil margin squeeze. Global aggregate bonds are the pressure valve: cycle-high yields are a price headwind, and duration only pays if the oil spike proves transitory. Gold's dip is not lost haven status — it is real-yield dominance, the one force that reliably fights it. Bitcoin trades as risk and liquidity, not a hedge, in a dollar-bid regime.³

CNBC, TradingEconomics, CME FedWatch (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

The oil bulls are fighting their own doubters. Analysts note that zero barrels have actually been disrupted — the shut routes have re-routed oil, not destroyed it — and Goldman Sachs' base case has Brent falling back toward eighty-five dollars, which would pull the inflation impulse, and the hike case, out from under this whole chain. Note too that the near-certain hike is a futures reading: prediction markets sit nearer a coin toss. A Fed that raises on a shock it cannot fix with rates risks tightening into a slowdown, and the hawkish path priced today may be the high-water mark, not the trend. Market explanation, not investment advice; forecasts are forecasts.³

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

DOLLAR-BID

REAL-YIELDS-UP

OIL SHOCK

One local read-through: the Monetary Authority manages the Singdollar rather than a rate, and its strong-currency stance sits on the tightening side of the same oil-shock story — a quiet import-price defence, with the Singdollar near one-twenty-seven to the greenback. And the classic hedge is under strain: equities and bonds are taking their cue from one rate fear at once, and even gold bent to it this week — a reminder that in a real-yields regime, the diversifier of last resort is cash and patience.³

DOWN THE RABBIT HOLE • MODERN BOARD GAMES

A fifteen-billion-dollar hobby, ranked by a single database — and it isn't Monopoly

This is the post-Catan world of designer games, chosen for the name on the box and argued over on one obsessively-kept list — split between the quiet point-salad Euro and the loud dice-and-story thematic.

Start with what it is not. It is not Monopoly, not the party game in the cupboard. Modern board gaming is a hobby of *designer games* — titles credited to and chosen for their designer, the way a film buff follows a director — and it splits into two great families.¹ **Euro games** are the German-descended school: resource management, engine-building, points scored many small ways, conflict kept indirect and luck kept low, with named auteurs — Uwe Rosenberg, the “point-salad” king Stefan Feld, the brain-burning economist Vital Lacerda. **Thematic** games, once nicknamed “Ameritrash,” are the opposite temperament: dice, direct conflict, story and big plastic, dramatic swings you feel.¹

The on-ramp everyone names is the same short list. The classic gateways — *Catan*, *Ticket to Ride*, *Carcassonne* — hand off to the modern trio that hooked this decade: *Wingspan*, *Azul*, *Splendor*, each cheap and quick and beautiful on a table.¹ The moment people fall in is usually a single game night where the mechanism clicks — the engine you built starts paying off — and a screen-free evening turns into a shelf.¹

The scale is larger than the cardboard suggests. The board-game market reached about fifteen-point-eight billion dollars in 2025, up from roughly fourteen-point-four the year before; Kickstarter alone took two hundred and seventy million dollars in games pledges in 2024, and the board-game crowdfunding segment nearly four hundred million.² BoardGameGeek — the hobby’s database, marketplace and argument-hall in one — passed four million registered users in early 2025; the r/boardgames forum runs near five and a half million; and the pilgrimage conventions are enormous, Gen Con drawing about seventy-two

thousand people to Indianapolis last August and Essen’s SPIEL more than two hundred thousand to Germany in October.²

Why it hooks a reader like this one is not a mystery. A board game is a finite, masterable object; it delivers a solve-the-puzzle hit without a screen; and it comes with a canon — the BoardGameGeek Top 100 — that quietly turns a pastime into a collection quest.³ The mid-forties, buy-once-cry-once buyer, perhaps introducing a twelve-year-old to the good stuff, is exactly the demographic the industry now designs its deluxe editions around.³

\$15.8bn

THE 2025 BOARD-GAME MARKET (UP FROM ~\$14.4BN);
KICKSTARTER TOOK ~\$270M IN GAMES PLEDGES IN 2024
ALONE

A finite, masterable object with a canon attached — a pastime the Top 100 turns into a quest.

THE CHATTER

The database has a scripture and a schism. Its number-one game, by the Bayesian-weighted “Geek Rating,” has been *Brass: Birmingham* — a dense industrial-revolution Euro — since February 2023, and the running grumble writes itself: “sigh, another heavy Euro at the top.” Whether the Top 100 over-rewards dry brain-burners over games people actually pull off the shelf is the fight that never ends on BGG.³

BoardGameGeek; r/boardgames (as reported)

What the next two pages descend into: the community map and the media that move it, the games by tier for a buy-once buyer, the deluxe-and-Kickstarter arms race, the cutting edge of the last twelve months, an honest first ninety days — and where the hype, the money pit and the pile of shame actually live.

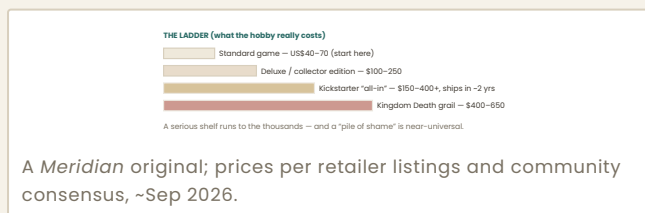
SOURCES 1 — BoardGameGeek, r/boardgames; Wikipedia (Euro vs thematic/“Ameritrash”; designers Rosenberg/Feld/Lacerda; gateway games *Catan*/*Ticket to Ride*/*Carcassonne* → *Wingspan*/*Azul*/*Splendor*). 2 — GMI Insights (market ~US\$15.83bn 2025, ~\$14.37bn 2024); Kickstarter/Updates (~\$270m games pledges 2024); GrowthMarketReports (board-game crowdfunding ~\$392m 2024); TableTok (BGG passed 4,000,000 users, Mar 2025); Hive Index (r/boardgames ~5.4m); BoardGameWire (Gen Con 2025 ~72,000; Essen SPIEL 2025 200,000+). 3 — Martin Fowler / Daily Worker Placement (*Brass: Birmingham* #1 since Feb 2023); community consensus on the Top 100 and deluxe-edition demographics, attributed. Market figures are analyst estimates ranging \$12.8–17.2bn; treated as such.

THE DEEP END · THE COMMUNITY, AND THE GAMES

From a forty-dollar box to a four-hundred-dollar Kickstarter — the ladder, and the reviewers who move it

The map has one capital and several provinces. **BoardGameGeek** is the capital — a database of every edition and expansion, a used-game marketplace (the GeekMarket), a rating culture built on a one-to-ten score and a weighted ranking, and “the Hotness,” the live list of what the hobby is talking about this hour.¹ Around it: **r/boardgames**, five and a half million strong and gateway-heavy, an endless “what should I buy?”; **r/hobbygames**, smaller and heavier; and **r/boardgamescirclejerk**, the satirical id where cardboard-hoarding and analysis paralysis get roasted.¹ The reviewers move markets: Britain’s witty **Shut Up & Sit Down** are near-kingmakers, the high-volume **Dice Tower** and Tom Vasel the institution, with Rahdo, No Pun Included, Watch It Played and BoardGameCo each owning a lane.¹

The games, by tier, start where most enthusiasts actually live — the modern mid-weight canon. *Wingspan*, the great gateway-plus, runs about sixty-five dollars; *Ark Nova*, the 2020s Euro darling, around fifty-three at discount; *Brass: Birmingham*, the database’s number one, seventy to seventy-five; *Everdell*, the table-presence icon with its three-dimensional tree, near sixty; and the co-op brain-burner *Spirit Island* is listed at eighty.² These are the shelf a buy-once buyer builds first — games that stay in rotation for years.²



Above the shelf sits the deluxe and campaign tier, where the money leaves quietly. Cephalofair’s legacy epics — *Gloomhaven* and its bigger sibling *Frosthaven*, near two hundred and fifty dollars — are hundred-hour boxes; Vital Lacerda’s heavy Euros sell

as deluxe bundles through Eagle-Gryphon; Chip Theory’s poker-chip *Too Many Bones* starts at a hundred and sixty; and the big Kickstarter houses, CMON and Awaken Realms, ship crates of painted plastic.² At the summit is the hobby’s curio-grail, *Kingdom Death: Monster* — roughly four hundred dollars at pledge, four-fifty to six-fifty on the secondary market — and a whole sub-industry of custom foam-and-wood inserts (*Folded Space*, *The Broken Token*, *GameTrayz*, *Laserox*) to tame the boxes.²

The cutting edge of the last twelve months is where the hobby argues about itself. The 2026 *Spiel des Jahres* — the industry’s Oscar, awarded in July — went to the light game *JinxO*, but the story was the connoisseur’s Kennerspiel prize going to Reiner Knizia’s *Rebirth*, completing a historic career sweep of all three jury awards for the most prolific designer alive.³ Stonemaier’s open-world *Vantage* landed in mid-2025 to famously divided reviews; Cole Wehrle’s *Arcs* and CGE’s *SETI* carried the critics; and Lacerda’s Prohibition game *Speakeasy* raised over a million and a quarter dollars from nine thousand backers on Kickstarter, ships due late this year.³

THE CHATTER · THE YEAR’S TWO FIGHTS

Two anxieties dominate the boards. Tariffs: with most games manufactured in China, US duties spiked toward a hundred and forty-five per cent before settling near thirty, Stonemaier faced millions in added cost and joined a lawsuit, and reviewers at Goonhammer dubbed 2025 the year “the Golden Age ends.” And AI art: a publisher’s use of generative art in a *Terraforming Mars* spin-off drew a backlash and a Kickstarter drop, and Essen’s SPIEL dropped its own AI-generated promo art after uproar. The crowdfunding centre of gravity, meanwhile, is sliding from Kickstarter toward Gamefound and BackerKit.³

BoardGameWire, Goonhammer, Stonemaier (as reported)

SOURCES 1 — BoardGameGeek (database, GeekMarket, Geek Rating, “the Hotness”); Hive Index (*r/boardgames* ~5.4m); *r/hobbygames*, *r/boardgamescirclejerk*; reviewer roles (*Shut Up & Sit Down*, *Dice Tower*/Tom Vasel, Rahdo, No Pun Included, Watch It Played, BoardGameCo), attributed. 2 — retailer/publisher listings (~Sep 2026); *Wingspan* ~\$65, *Ark Nova* ~\$53, *Brass: Birmingham* ~\$70-75, *Everdell* ~\$60, *Spirit Island* ~\$80, *Frosthaven* ~\$250, *Too Many Bones* from \$159.99, *Kingdom Death: Monster* ~\$400 (secondary \$450-650); inserts *Folded Space*/*Broken Token*/*GameTrayz*/*Laserox*. 3 — BoardGameWire, WEric Martin (*Spiel des Jahres 2026: JinxO*; Kennerspiel *Rebirth*, Knizia triple; 2025 *Bomb Busters*); Meeple Mountain/ICv2 (*Vantage* divisive, Jul 2025); Kickstarter (*Lacerda Speakeasy* ~\$1.26m/9,368 backers); Goonhammer/Stonemaier (tariffs ~145% → 30%, lawsuit); BoardGameWire (AI-art backlash; Gamefound/BackerKit). Some prices single-source; SdJ main winner confirm. Confirm live.

THE DEEP END · THE CULTURE, THE FIRST NINETY DAYS, THE FEAR

The pile of shame, the cult of the new, and how to start without a shelf of regret

The culture runs on factions and a shared vocabulary. The great divide is Euro versus thematic — the point-salad optimisers against the dice-and-story crowd — crossed by a second, the “cult of the new” chasing every release against the “classics are enough” holdouts, and a third between crowdfunding evangelists and Kickstarter sceptics.¹ The classic beginner mistakes are always the same: buying a heavy game before a group exists, teaching the rules badly, and chasing the Top 100 instead of matching a game to the table you actually have.¹ The rituals are the pilgrimage conventions — Gen Con, Essen’s SPIEL, the UK Games Expo, BGG.CON — and the weekly game night, with the BoardGameGeek Top 100 read as scripture.¹

THE GLOSSARY

LEARN THESE SIX

Euro — points-driven, low-conflict, resource-and-engine design (Wingspan, Brass).

Ameritrash / thematic — dice, conflict, story, big minis; the opposite temperament.

Worker placement — claiming action-spaces with tokens; the Euro workhorse mechanic.

Engine-building — setting up combos that snowball as the game goes on.

AP — analysis paralysis; a player frozen over too many options, the game-night killer.

The pile of shame — the games owned but never played; near-universal.

The economics are honest once named. A standard game is forty to seventy dollars; a deluxe or collector edition a hundred to two hundred and fifty; a Kickstarter “all-in,” with its exclusives and stretch goals, a hundred and fifty to four hundred and delivered in about two years; and a serious shelf runs to the thousands, a pile of shame all but guaranteed.² The first ninety days, then, are an exercise in restraint. Lurk first — a month of Shut Up & Sit Down, the Dice Tower and r/boardgames saves a shelf of regret — then buy small: a gateway engine-builder (Wingspan, about sixty-five dollars, or Azul at twenty-five), one social win that plays with a twelve-year-old (Ticket to Ride, thirty to forty-five), and one

co-operative game so no one loses first (the gentle Pandemic at thirty-five, or the deep Spirit Island).²

Where you buy matters as much as what. Support a local game store for the advice and play space at near-Amazon prices; use Amazon or Miniature Market for the cheapest sealed boxes; and mine the BoardGameGeek GeekMarket for used copies — the true buy-once bargains. A group is found the same way a game is: BGG’s local forums, Meetup, or a board-game café on a quiet weeknight.²

THE SCEPTIC

The hobby’s honest confession is that it buys faster than it plays. The Kickstarter machine turns a sixty-dollar game into a three-hundred-dollar commitment you wait two years for; the cult of the new means the eleven hundred debuts at a single Essen make last year’s must-have obsolete by the next; and the deluxe upsell — metal coins, resin minis, a two-hundred-and-fifty-dollar collector box — rarely changes how a game plays: “you’re paying four hundred dollars for plastic you’ll play twice” is the line r/boardgamescirclejerk keeps ready. And the heaviest games are the hardest to get to the table: analysis paralysis grinds a night to a halt, and the group is the real bottleneck.³

The Singapore angle: the scene has real anchors — Battle Bunker (Bugis+ and West Coast Plaza), the island’s largest hobby store, and Games @ PI on Orchard Road — plus a board-game-café circuit.³ Two local realities: many deluxe and Kickstarter boxes ship from abroad, so watch import GST and freight; and at around eighty per cent humidity, cardboard warps — store games in sealed totes with silica gel, not stacked in the open.³

NEXT DESCENTS · YOU PICK THE NEXT RABBIT HOLE

Home espresso — the buy-once mirror of this hobby: a dual-boiler machine, a grinder that costs as much, and shots dialled in by the gram and the second.

Mechanical keyboards — group buys, artisan keycaps, lubed switches, and an “endgame” board that never quite ends.

Speedcubing — a sixty-dollar magnetic cube, records in milliseconds, and a global competition ladder; cheap to enter, bottomless to master.

SOURCES 1 — BoardGameGeek, r/boardgames, r/boardgamescirclejerk: factions (Euro/thematic, cult-of-the-new, crowdfunding), beginner mistakes, conventions (Gen Con, Essen SPIEL, UK Games Expo, BGG.CON), the Top 100 as canon; attributed. 2 — retailer/BGG listings (~Sep 2026): Wingspan ~\$65, Azul ~\$25, Ticket to Ride ~\$30–45, Pandemic ~\$35, Spirit Island \$80; LGS vs Amazon/Miniature Market vs GeekMarket (used); Meetup/BGG local forums for groups. 3 — Stonemaier “math of tariffs,” ShelfGamer (AP), r/boardgamescirclejerk (pile of shame/deluxe upsell); Battle Bunker, Games @ PI (SG stores); StorHub (SG humidity storage, ~80% RH, silica gel/totes). Community sentiment attributed; single-source items flagged.

THE LONG GAME • THE DRUG THAT MAKES YOU MOVE LESS

The weight comes off on a GLP-1 — and so, quietly, do the daily steps

A 2026 study finds people move measurably less after starting the weight-loss drugs, just when movement matters most. The muscle-melt panic that dominates the discourse, meanwhile, looks like the wrong worry — and the real fix is the same either way.

The counter-intuitive finding lands on the reader's own peer group. Researchers presenting at the Endocrine Society's 2026 meeting reported that adults with obesity *reduced* their physical activity after starting a GLP-1 medication — the opposite of the assumption that losing weight frees you to move more.¹ Drawing on Fitbit data from the American All of Us programme, the team led by Sajana Maharjan looked at nearly two thousand patients prescribed the drugs; among the seven hundred and fifty-three with enough wearable data, daily steps fell from about five thousand to four and a half thousand — roughly five hundred and sixty fewer a day — and moderate-to-vigorous activity dropped from twenty-eight minutes to twenty-two.¹ “Exercise cannot be optional for people taking these medications,” the lead author warned.¹

Why it matters is the compounding worry beneath it. Older analyses put a fifth to a third of the weight lost on these drugs as lean mass, not fat — and a body both shedding muscle and moving less walks into midlife with less of the one tissue most tied to how the next decades go.¹ The drug removes the appetite, and some of the impulse to move; muscle pays for that twice.²

But the loudest part of the discourse — that GLP-1s “melt” muscle — looks overstated. A study in *Cell Reports Medicine* in March found that GLP-1 weight loss did *not* cause disproportionate muscle loss: absolute muscle mass dips, as it does in any weight loss, but relative muscle mass and strength per kilogram actually improve, and in humans grip and knee-extension strength did not significantly worsen.² The American Council on Science and Health called the muscle scare exactly that.²

Which leaves a single, unglamorous instruction. If you or a peer goes on one of these drugs, lift and eat protein — resistance training two or three times a

week, around one-and-a-half grams per kilogram — and treat the step count as a number to defend, not assume. The activity dip is the better-evidenced risk than catastrophic muscle-melt, and the same prescription answers both. General fitness information, not medical advice.²

-560

DAILY STEPS LOST AFTER STARTING A GLP-1, IN THE ENDO 2026 FITBIT ANALYSIS — THE DRUG REMOVES APPETITE, AND SOME OF THE MOVEMENT TOO

THE CHATTER • THE LONGEVITY READ

The finding plays straight to the Attia-and-Huberman crowd, for whom “muscle is the organ of longevity” is an article of faith — and the lifter communities have already published GLP-1 “recomposition” playbooks: lift heavy, hit the protein target, stop watching only the scale. These drugs are a tool that *demands* a training programme, not one that replaces it.²

Attia/Huberman-adjacent; ACE, lifter communities (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

Read the headline finding with its caveats attached. The ENDO 2026 study is a conference abstract, not yet peer-reviewed; it is observational, on self-selected Fitbit wearers; and five hundred and sixty fewer steps a day is real but modest — do not extrapolate it to “the drugs make everyone sedentary.” Equally, do not let it feed the muscle-melt panic the better-controlled trial just deflated. The honest, boring synthesis: the drugs work for weight, the movement dip is the risk to manage, and lifting plus protein is the management. Not medical advice.²

STILL ON THE SHELF

The family crossover. The Family Desk makes the same argument a generation down (p13): the easy thing that quietly removes your movement — a drug for the adult, a feed for the child — is the thing to watch. Defend the daily activity; the rest follows.

SOURCES 1 — ENDO 2026 (Endocrine Society annual meeting), Maharjan et al., via endocrine.org press release, Healio, Medical Daily, Medscape: adults with obesity reduced activity after starting a GLP-1 RA; of 1,950 prescribed, 753 with sufficient Fitbit data; steps 5,047 → 4,487 (~560/day), MVPA 27.9 → 22.2 min/day; “exercise cannot be optional.” Conference abstract, observational, self-selected. 2 — *Cell Reports Medicine* (17 Mar 2026; DOI 10.1016/j.xcrm.2026.102665): GLP-1 weight loss not disproportionate muscle loss; relative muscle/strength improve, grip/knee-extension unchanged, liver-mass loss > muscle; ACSH commentary (muscle scare overstated); ~20–30% lean-mass share in older analyses; Attia/Huberman & lifter “recomposition” guidance. General fitness information, not medical advice.

WHAT'S WORTH BOOKING · THE DATED AGENDA

A Grand Prix with its first Sprint, a snowless clock ticking, and a sumo that goes on sale this weekend

The autumn calendar fills: book the marquees now, note the one that closes for good on the thirtieth, and be ready when the Fukuoka tickets drop on Saturday.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 21–27
SEP

Singapore Tennis Open (WTA 500)
 OCBC ARENA, KALLANG · UPGRADED TOUR STOP · NEAR-TERM, FAMILY-FRIENDLY¹
- 19–27
SEP

Mid-Autumn Festival
 GARDENS BY THE BAY / CHINATOWN · LANTERNS TO 4 OCT · FREE FAMILY EVENING
- 30
SEP

★ Snow City — final day
 JURONG · THE INDOOR SNOW SLOPE CLOSSES FOR GOOD AFTER 26 YEARS · FAREWELL \$S19/\$S16, DO-IT-NOW WITH THE KIDS¹
- 02–03
OCT

The Weeknd — After Hours til Dawn
 NATIONAL STADIUM · ON SALE SINCE MAY · THIN INVENTORY
- 09–11
OCT

★ F1 Singapore Grand Prix — first-ever Sprint
 MARINA BAY STREET CIRCUIT · RACE SUN 11 OCT · ZONE 4 GA FROM ~\$S198/DAY, AVAILABILITY CRITICALLY LOW¹
- to 18
OCT

Official F1 Exhibition
 GARDENS BY THE BAY · FIVE HERO CARS · THE DAUGHTER-FRIENDLY RACE-WEEK WARM-UP¹
- 17–18
OCT

BIGBANG
 NATIONAL STADIUM · FROM \$S194 · 17 OCT SOLD OUT, 18 OCT RELEASED
- 10–11
NOV

My Chemical Romance
 SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · FROM ~\$S350 · 2ND NIGHT ON DEMAND
- 25
NOV

Guns N' Roses
 NATIONAL STADIUM · FROM ~\$S150 · THE REUNION LINE-UP
- 28–29
NOV

Babymonster — [CHOOM] Tour
 INDOOR STADIUM · \$S168–358 · THE YG ROOKIE GROUP'S SG STOP
- 13–18
APR

Bruno Mars — The Romantic Tour
 NATIONAL STADIUM, APR 2027 · WITH ANDERSON .PAAK · GENERAL SALE OPENED MON 14 SEP²

JAPAN & THE REGION

FLY-FOR · PLAN THE TRIP

- 08–22
NOV

★ Kyushu Basho (grand sumo)
 FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · TICKETS ON-SALE 19 SEP (TICKET OOSUMO) · CHAIR ~¥4,000–6,000²
- Autumn
2026

The Louvre @ National Art Center, Tokyo
 ROPPONGI · FIFTY-PLUS WORKS INCL. RENAISSANCE HOLDINGS · AN AUTUMN MARQUEE SHOW
- Late
NOV

Kyoto & Tokyo autumn leaves
 PEAK KOYO MID-LATE NOV (MEIJI JINGU GAIEN, RIKUGIEN) · BOOK RYOKAN & SHINKANSEN EARLY
- 20
Nov–14
Mar

Sapporo White Illumination
 ODORI PARK, SAPPORO · FREE · JAPAN'S ORIGINAL CITY LIGHT-UP, PLUS A GERMAN MARKET
- 04
FEB

★ Sapporo Snow Festival
 EARLY FEB 2027 · HOKKAIDO · FAMILY SNOW SLIDES; BOOK FLIGHTS & HOTELS NOW
- 22
Jan–01
Feb

System of a Down + Faith No More
 AUSTRALIA STADIUMS (SYDNEY/MELBOURNE/BRISBANE) 2027 · FIRST AU RUN IN A DECADE

SOURCES 1 — SingaporeGP, VisitSingapore, Snow City, The Urban List (Sep 2026): F1 SG GP + first-ever Sprint 9–11 Oct (race 11 Oct, GA from ~\$S198/day, availability critically low); Official F1 Exhibition to 18 Oct (Gardens by the Bay); Snow City final day 30 Sep (farewell \$S19/\$S16); Singapore Tennis Open (WTA 500) 21–27 Sep; Mid-Autumn 19–27 Sep. 2 — Live Nation SG, Ticketmaster SG, Harper's Bazaar SG, Bandwagon, Ticket Oosumo (13–14 Sep): The Weeknd 2–3 Oct (on sale since May); BIGBANG 17–18 Oct (17 sold out, from \$S194); MCR 10–11 Nov Indoor Stadium (~\$S350); Guns N' Roses 25 Nov (~\$S150); Babymonster 28–29 Nov (\$S168–358); Bruno Mars general sale opened Mon 14 Sep (Romantic Tour, 13–18 Apr 2027, w/ Anderson .Paak); Kyushu Basho on-sale 19 Sep. Events re-checked still-on against reported promoter/ticketing announcements; Post Malone remains cancelled and is not listed.

THE TABLE · SINGAPORE'S NEWEST COUNTERS

A Michelin chef's looser second act, a Korean chicken giant's return, and a garden dining house still finding itself

Three openings, one booked solid until December — and the honest notes on the two that are still too new to call.

A ssaggi, 77A Neil Road. This is the one to book — if you can. It is the looser, “imperfect by choice” second act of Denis Lucchi, the chef behind the one-Michelin-starred Buona Terra, and it trades the fine-dining hush for set menus done properly: a three-course lunch around fifty-eight dollars before service, two dinner tasting journeys near eighty-eight.¹ The early consensus across the food press is warm and unfussy — praised precisely for not posturing and for nailing the fundamentals rather than the theatre — and the tell on demand is blunt: reviewers report you cannot get a table until December.¹ Reserve weeks out, or don't bother.

Mom's Touch, 181 South Bridge Road. South Korea's largest fried-chicken chain — more than fourteen hundred outlets at home — has returned to Singapore four years after pulling out entirely, and it came back with a hook: hand-battered, cook-to-order patties made from a hundred per cent chicken thigh, plus Singapore-only items and an early breakfast menu, open from seven in the morning.² The Super Thigh burger runs under ten dollars, and the reception across the food media has been enthusiastic on the size and juiciness — with the honest caveat that this is fast food, not a destination meal, and the real story is the queue. Off-peak, or wait for the promised second outlet. Not halal-certified.²

Tembusu, Singapore Botanic Gardens. Taking over the long-running Halia space in the Ginger Garden, Tembusu is a “borderless Straits” dining house from the Fleursophy group — fully air-conditioned, pet-friendly, running from a kaya-toast breakfast through to a nine o'clock dinner.³ The coverage leans hard on the setting, a genuinely lovely garden room; the food verdicts are early and mixed-to-fair, which is fair enough for a kitchen that only came out of soft

launch in early September. Go for the location and the Straits-comfort angle now; wait a month before judging the plate.³

On the watch-list. Nancy Silverton's Osteria Mozza — the only Asian outpost of her Cal-Italian — has decamped from Hilton Singapore Orchard to a larger, more social room at ION Orchard, adding Roman-style pizza alla pala and her soft-serve; there is no settled post-move verdict yet, so it goes here as a lead.³ And the Tian Tian flagship at Jewel, flagged last month, keeps drawing crowds — still the heritage opening the round-ups can't stop mentioning.¹

THE CHATTER · THE BUZZ

The food press has been fondest of Assaggi — HungryGoWhere, City Nomads and the review blogs all reading it as a confident, unshowy room from a chef with nothing to prove — and the December waitlist is doing the marketing. Mom's Touch is pure mass-market buzz, queue-managed rather than divisive; Tembusu draws the “what a setting” line more than the “what a meal” one, which is the tell of a place still settling.¹

HungryGoWhere, City Nomads, Eatbook (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

An opening is not a verdict. Tembusu and Osteria Mozza have each barely served a settled service, so treat the early praise as anticipation, not judgement — a lovely room and a famous name are hooks the kitchen still has to earn. And be honest about register: Mom's Touch is a very good fast-food burger, not a reason to cross town, and the queue is the experience as much as the chicken. The one with a real claim on your evening is the one you can't get into until December.¹

NEIL ROAD

CHINATOWN

BOTANIC GARDENS

TOO NEW TO CALL

SOURCES 1 — HungryGoWhere, The Ranting Panda, middleclass.sg, City Nomads (Aug–Sep 2026): Assaggi, 77A Neil Road, opened 10 Aug, Chef Denis Lucchi (Buona Terra 1*), set menus only (lunch ~\$58++, dinner tasting ~\$88++); warm reception, reportedly booked to December; Tian Tian Jewel still drawing crowds. 2 — SETHLUI, Eatbook, HungryGoWhere (Aug–Sep 2026): Mom's Touch, 181 South Bridge Road, reopened 14 Aug (Korea's largest fried-chicken chain, 1,400+ outlets, returns after 4 yrs), 100% thigh patties, Super Thigh burger ~\$9.95, breakfast from 7am; positive on size/juiciness, queues the story, not halal-certified. 3 — HungryGoWhere, The Ordinary Patrons, Tatler Asia (Aug–Sep 2026): Tembusu, Ginger Garden, Singapore Botanic Gardens (former Halia), open 3 Sep, Fleursophy “borderless Straits,” pet-friendly, setting praised/food early-mixed; Osteria Mozza (Nancy Silverton) relocated to ION Orchard, no settled verdict. Prices ~Sep 2026; confirm on booking.

THE UNDERCURRENT · SOUTH KOREA

Running crew: how the country with the lowest birthrate on earth rebuilds the commons at dawn

The world files South Korea under “dying.” Yet ten million people now call themselves runners, gathering along the Han in loose, opt-in crews — and two backlashes this year reveal exactly what a community without obligation costs.

Come to the Han River at dusk and the story is already running past you. Along the riverside paths at Yeouido and Banpo, in the parks under Namsan, clusters of people in their twenties and thirties gather at a fixed time and a fixed place, stretch, and set off together — the 러닝크루, the running crew, organised on Instagram and Strava and a group chat, opt-in and low-commitment, a standing appointment with strangers who become something like friends.¹ Running in Korea has stopped being solitary exercise and become the default social operating system of a generation.¹

The scale is genuinely large. Korea now counts something like ten million runners, roughly double the five million of 2017; the share of the population that jogs rose from about twenty-three per cent in 2021 to thirty-two in 2023.¹ The money followed: the domestic sneaker market grew from two-point-seven-trillion won in 2021 to over four trillion by 2024, running shoes alone passing a trillion won — around seven hundred and thirty million US dollars — and searches for “running” jumped more than eighty per cent year on year, with people in their twenties and thirties accounting for some seventy-two per cent of running-related spending.¹ Even the state has joined in: Seoul’s own official crew, the “7979 Seoul Urban Running Crew,” tripled from about three hundred members to a thousand in a single year.¹

What the crew offers is a particular kind of belonging — and what it leaves out is the point. It is community without the obligations the young are walking away

from: not the family they are, in record numbers, not forming; not the church; and not the company after-hours drink, the 회식, that MERIDIAN’s “sober generation” (No. 80) has been quietly leaving. Korean outlets call it the “soft community” an individualistic generation wanted: a place to belong that you can join on Tuesday and quit on Thursday, that asks for a pace and not a life.²

~10m

KOREANS WHO NOW CALL THEMSELVES RUNNERS — NEARLY ONE IN FIVE CITIZENS, IN THE COUNTRY WITH THE LOWEST BIRTHRATE ON EARTH

A place to belong that you can join on Tuesday and quit on Thursday — that asks for a pace, not a life.

That design is the whole appeal, and it is the reason the story matters beyond Seoul. Here is a society the world has filed under demographic collapse — a fertility rate near zero-point-seven, the “N-po generation” that has given up dating and marriage and much else besides, the poster child for atomisation — and it is doing the opposite of what the label predicts: rebuilding a public, in the flesh, at dawn.² The commons did not vanish; it was re-founded on the riverbank, one Strava upload at a time. The question the next two pages ask is what happens when you try to build community and strip the obligation out of it — and it turns out the obligation was load-bearing.²

SOURCES 1 — Korea Gallup via SEN.TV / Sisa Magazine, Euromonitor via SEN.TV, Seoul Metropolitan Government / Korea Herald (2025–26): ~10m runners (from ~5m in 2017); jogging participation ~23% (2021) → ~32% (2023); sneaker market 2.77tn won (2021) → >4tn (2024), running shoes >1tn won (~US\$730m) 2024; “running” search +82% YoY; 2030s ~72% of running-related spending; “7979 Seoul Urban Running Crew” ~300 (2024) → ~1,000 (2025). 2 — Korean press (SEN.TV, Sisa Magazine, Korea Times) on the “soft community” framing; MERIDIAN No. 80 (the “sober generation” leaving the 회식); Korea’s ~0.7 total fertility rate. Figures are outlet-reported; sneaker/market data attributed to Euromonitor, participation to Korea Gallup.

A crowd that size does not stay frictionless. The first backlash of 2026 is over public space — 민폐, the Korean word for the nuisance you inflict on others — and it has moved from grumble to notice board. This month the National Palace Museum near Gyeongbokgung posted a public warning against running crews clogging its free lockers and gathering spots; earlier in the year citizens complained that crews behave “as if they had rented the whole path” — 전세 낸 것처럼 — and several Seoul parks put up notices limiting large group runs and loud cheering.¹ Television newsmagazines ran exposés of crews shouting “get out of the way” and blocking riverside paths for group photos.¹

This is the friction the “soft community” was engineered to avoid, arriving anyway. A crew is opt-in and obligation-free to its members; to the pensioner walking the same path, it is forty strangers who have annexed the commons for an hour. The riverbank was public before it was theirs, and the war over it is the oldest civic argument there is, wearing running shoes.¹



The second backlash is stranger, and more revealing: a trust panic. In September a private investigator went public with the case of a husband who joined a Han River crew and began meeting a female member privately, presenting it as emblematic of a wave of “sports-club” affairs.² A maxim spread across the relationship forums — “if your boyfriend or girlfriend joins a running crew, break up” — and a parallel scene of open match-making, nicknamed “patriotic hunting” at Olympic Park, made explicit what the crews had quietly become: not only a place to run, but a marketplace to meet.²

~1,000

MEMBERS OF SEOUL'S OFFICIAL “7979” CREW, UP FROM ~300 A YEAR EARLIER — BELONGING, FRANCHISED BY CITY HALL

“If your boyfriend or girlfriend joins a running crew, break up” — the panic, in one line.

Handle the trust story carefully, because it is the softest evidence in the piece. The infidelity claims are reported anecdote and forum sentiment, amplified by an investigator with a service to sell and headlines to earn — not survey data, and not proof of a real epidemic of affairs.² What is real is the anxiety, and the anxiety is the tell. A society reaches for “break up if they join a crew” only when the crew has become intimate enough to threaten a marriage — which is to say, when the soft community has quietly hardened into the real thing, with all the jealousy and betrayal the real thing carries.²

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE CREWS SAY

The crews recruit and organise on Instagram and open KakaoTalk chats, and their own defence is consistent: they are the one place a burned-out twenty-something can make friends without a bar tab or a workplace hierarchy, and the nuisance complaints are a small, loud minority tarring a mostly-considerate majority. The counter, from the same platforms, is blunter — a public path is not a private track, and a group photo is not worth a blocked walkway. Both sides are arguing, in effect, over who the commons belongs to.¹

Instagram / KakaoTalk crew accounts; Korean press (as reported)

Put the two backlashes side by side and they rhyme. The public-nuisance fights and the infidelity investigators are both the return of exactly what the frictionless crew was supposed to spare its members: the stranger's claim on shared space, and the lover's claim on shared loyalty.¹ You can strip the obligation out of the invitation. You cannot strip it out of what people do to one another once they are in the same place, at the same time, week after week.²

SOURCES 1 — Financial News (파이낸셜뉴스, 4 Sep 2026: National Palace Museum notice against crews); Korea Economic Daily (한국경제, May 2026: “전세 낸 것처럼”); SBS 8 News, JTBC Newsroom (2026 nuisance segments); Korea Times / SCMP (Seoul parks limiting group runs). 2 — Financial News (7 Sep 2026: private-investigator “sports-club” affair); Insight.co.kr (viral “break up if they join a running crew” maxim); Seoul Shinmun (서울신문, 15 Jun 2026: “애국 헌팅” matchmaking at Olympic Park). Infidelity/dating claims are reported sentiment and anecdote, not survey data — carried as attributed reportage, not fact. Korean-language outlets read via search this cycle.

Here is the argument, and it runs against the headline. A quarter-century ago the political scientist Robert Putnam wrote *Bowling Alone*, mourning the collapse of the American bowling league and the civic clubs alongside it as the draining of a nation's social capital — people still bowled, but they bowled alone.¹ Korea, the developed world's champion of atomisation, is running the tape backward: a generation that has opted out of family, church and company is opting back into the flesh, together, at dawn on the riverbank. They stopped bowling alone; they started running in crews.¹

But look at *how* they rebuilt it, because that is the insight. This is not the old civic body reconstituted — the club with dues, minutes and a difficult treasurer you cannot avoid. It is community re-founded as a *product*: opt-in, brandable, quitable, obligation-free, discovered through an app and abandoned without a phone call. The 러닝크루 is the Rotary Club of the burnout age — belonging on demand, minus the hometown, the pew and the 회식.¹ The West has filed the “Korea is dying” story many times over; it has not yet filed this one, the same generation jogging its way back into the same room.¹

THE SCEPTIC · HOLD THE NUMBERS HONESTLY

Keep the frame on the Korean meaning, not on “running is trendy” — the West already ran the generic “run clubs are the new dating apps” take for its own cities, and that is the trope to stay ahead of, not to repeat.² The figures deserve their caveats too: the widely-cited jump from nineteen marathons to two hundred and fifty-four is outlet-reported, not traced to a governing body; the “billion-dollar industry” is a softer estimate than the Euromonitor won figures; and the infidelity wave is sentiment, not data. The claim that survives all of it is directional: participation has doubled, and the young are gathering, in person, at scale.²

And then the bill arrives, which is the turn the trend-pieces will miss. You can strip the obligation out of the invitation; you cannot strip it out of what people do once they are in the same place, week after week.

The crew promised community without commitment — and the public-nuisance notices and the “break up if they join” meme are the invoice, the stranger's claim on the path and the lover's claim on loyalty both returning uninvited.¹ The obligation the design tried to delete turns out to have been load-bearing: it was the thing that made a community more than a scheduled crowd.²

They stopped bowling alone; they started running in crews — and found the old costs waiting at the finish line.

There is a reason this reaches a Singapore reader beyond the curiosity. This island is on the same demographic curve — a birthrate among the world's lowest, a rising tide of solo living, and its own run-club and social-fitness boom filling the reservoir loops on a weeknight.² Korea is simply a few years ahead, running the experiment at full scale: what a society builds when the old institutions empty out, and what it costs when the replacement is designed to ask for nothing. The answer, so far, is that the friction comes back — and that may be the most hopeful thing in the story, because friction is what a real community is made of.²

The obligation the design tried to delete turns out to have been load-bearing.

So carry this out of Seoul before the feature writers arrive: the most-atomised society on earth is not, in fact, only atomising. It is also, quietly, at six in the morning, reassembling — not into the family or the firm the state keeps trying to subsidise back into being, but into a looser thing that fits a generation's terms and then, stubbornly, grows the old teeth anyway. When the FT runs “how South Korea's run clubs rebuilt community” three weeks from now, the reader of this page will already know the harder half — that they rebuilt the costs, too.¹

SOURCES 1 — Robert Putnam, *Bowling Alone* (2000); Korean press (SEN.TV, Sisa Magazine, Korea Times, Korea Herald, SCMP, 2025–26) on the 러닝크루 phenomenon and the 2026 backlashes; MERIDIAN No. 80 (회식 / the “sober generation”). Under-radar check: no NYT/BBC/Reuters/FT feature on the Korean running-crew phenomenon or its 2026 민폐/infidelity backlashes at time of writing; Western coverage runs the generic “run clubs are the new dating apps” angle for the US/UK only. 2 — Meridian analysis; caveats on outlet-reported figures (marathon count, “\$1bn industry,” infidelity sentiment); Singapore's own low fertility, solo-living and social-fitness trends drawn without inventing SG figures. Key term for the ledger: 러닝크루 (running crew).

M E R I D I A N

THE LAST WORD

The friction you cannot design out

The week kept teaching one lesson in different rooms. A Federal Reserve met a shock it cannot fix — you can raise the price of money, but you cannot rate your way out of a closed strait, and gold fell to prove it. A city met an old law that has never once worked and reached instead for cooling rooms and masks.

And in Seoul, a generation tried to build a community with the friction engineered out — no dues, no obligation, quit any Thursday — and found the friction waiting at the finish line, in a fight over a footpath and a maxim about who not to marry. The buy-once desks answer in the same key from the other side: some things are made to be rebuilt, not replaced — a boot you resole for decades, a watch whose battery you never change — permanence chosen on purpose, because the honest version of a thing costs its friction up front. The easy lever is always cheaper. It is also, reliably, the one that does not hold.

T W E L V E D E S K S · O N E W O R L D

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